INTERNATIONAL CLIMATE AGREEMENT

COOK ISLANDS CLIMATE AND INDIGENOUS HERITAGE TREATY

Rarotonga, Cook Islands 2063

PREAMBLE

Recognizing the threats climate change poses to the Cook Islands, including rising sea levels, coastal erosion, extreme weather, coral bleaching, and food and water insecurity while also acknowledging the deep cultural and ancestral connections Indigenous Cook Islanders have with their lands and oceans, and affirming their right to govern and manage their natural resources; The participating parties establish this treaty to restore decision-making power to Indigenous communities, protect their cultural heritage and ecosystems, and ensure that climate adaptation and environmental policies are led by the people most connected to the land.

ARTICLE I — INDIGENOUS LAND GOVERNANCE

Indigenous Cook Islanders shall hold primary authority over the management, protection, and use of their ancestral lands, ensuring traditional knowledge and cultural practices guide environmental decisions.

ARTICLE II — RESOURCE EXTRACTION AND INDIGENOUS CONSENT

No deep-sea mining or other major resource extraction project affecting Indigenous lands, waters, or cultural heritage shall proceed without the informed consent of affected Indigenous communities.

ARTICLE III — FUNDING AND SELF-DETERMINATION

Participating international partners shall provide direct financial and technical support to Indigenous-led conservation and climate adaptation initiatives, ensuring that communities have the resources necessary to manage their territories independently and restore their natural environment.

ARTICLE IV — CULTURAL AND ANCESTRAL HERITAGE

The treaty shall protect sacred sites, traditional knowledge, ancestral burial grounds, and cultural practices from environmental destruction. Indigenous communities shall determine how their heritage is preserved and passed on to future generations.

ARTICLE V — PROTECTION OF OCEANS AND MARINE RESOURCES

Indigenous communities shall have the authority to establish and manage marine protected areas, regulate traditional fishing practices, and safeguard coral reefs and marine biodiversity within their territories.

SIGNATORIES

Signed in Rarotonga, Cook Islands, 2063

Cook Islands Government Representative

New Zealand Representative

Australia Representative